

Taking over the second homework gets hard

8 findings · 13-step checklist · 4 sources · cheatgrid.com

Yes, but keep the problem theirs. Their struggle raises your own tension and makes reaching for the pencil feel responsible, though the hours you put in don't by themselves decide how they do.

THE GOAL

You're trying to get them through this one without teaching them that stalling hands it to you. Slide the worksheet back and ask where exactly they got stuck.

CHECKLIST

Your kid pushes the worksheet toward you, pencil down, and says they can't do it.

- ☐ **Slide the worksheet back** in front of them instead of pulling it toward you.
- ☐ Ask them to point to the exact line or word where they got stuck.
- ☐ Ask what they've already tried, or how they were thinking about it, before you say anything else.
- ☐ If they can describe an idea or a step, tell them to run with it instead of starting over.
- ☐ If they can't start at all, give the **smallest hint** that unblocks just the next step, not the whole method.
- ☐ Wait quietly for a few seconds after giving a hint before saying anything else.
- ☐ If a first hint doesn't work, give one more specific hint, naming the exact step they're missing, still short of the full method.
- ☐ Once they land on an answer, ask them to explain how they got it rather than checking it yourself.
- ☐ If two hints haven't worked, say out loud that this one is a hard problem, instead of switching to doing it yourself.
- ☐ If they get frustrated or put themselves down, name that this part is hard instead of finishing it for them.
- ☐ Set a limit together, like five more minutes, then either move on or write down what's left.
- ☐ When the limit is up, write down the exact step or type of problem that tripped them up, in words you'll recognize later.
- ☐ If this is the same kind of problem that tripped them up earlier this week, write that down too, to mention to their teacher.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1 Watching your kid come up short on something raises **your own tension** about it too.
- 2 Your kid's struggling is often what pushes you to **take over**, not proof you weren't hands-on enough.
- 3 How often you sit down to help, by itself, isn't linked to better grades.

What's actually pulling you to jump in

KNOW

Watching your kid come up short on something raises **your own tension** about it too.

Parents told their child was about to fail a task reported feeling more tense about it than parents told their child would succeed. [Source 1](#)

KNOW

Your kid's struggling is often what pushes you to **take over**, not proof you weren't hands-on enough. Researchers guessed the mix of time pressure and expected failure felt urgent enough that stepping in became almost automatic. [Source 1](#)

What taking over costs, and what it doesn't fix

KNOW

Long-run studies keep finding the same pattern: kids whose parents support their thinking through a problem do better in school over time.

The pattern shows up in general school studies and in studies of homework specifically. [Source 2](#)

WATCH

Jumping in with directions the moment they struggle is what researchers call controlling homework help.

Asking what they think makes help feel supportive. [Source 2](#)

KNOW

How often you sit down to help, by itself, isn't linked to better grades.

Helping more often actually went with lower scores in one homework study, even accounting for how kids had already been doing. [Source 3](#)

KNOW

What matters for grades isn't how often a parent helps. The difference is feeling supported, not taken over.

Feeling supported went with higher scores and feeling taken over went with lower ones, in one homework study. [Source 3](#)

What actually helps when they're stuck

DO

Offer the smallest hint first when they're stuck, then get more specific only if that doesn't unblock them.

Starting with the smallest hint lets your kid solve as much of the problem as they can before you say anything more. [Source 4](#)

DON'T

Don't assume waiting it out always helps, even for teenagers doing algebra.

Students with the least background did better getting help quickly than recovering alone, in a study of computer-tutored algebra. [Source 4](#)

Sources

1. https://selfdeterminationtheory.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/07/2017_WuytsVansteenkisteMabbeSoenens_ContempEdPsych.pdf
2. https://selfdeterminationtheory.org/wp-content/uploads/2025/09/2022_GrolnickPomerantz_ShouldParents.pdf
3. https://folia.unifr.ch/rerodoc/258053/files/44Niggli_2015_JoER.pdf
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Read it online, with the rest of the set

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